

Corpus callosum

This bundle of nerves connects the two halves—the left and right sides—of the brain. The nerves thicken during adolescence and improve problem-solving abilities.

Being clumsy

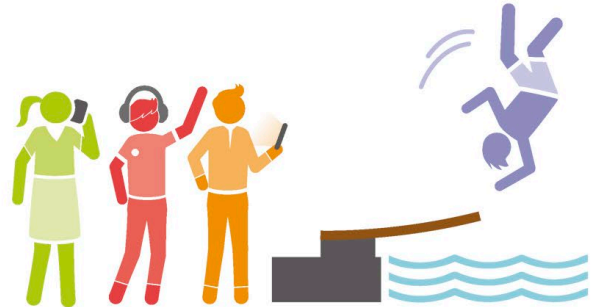
During puberty, growth spurts—when a teen grows quickly in a short space of time—can leave the brain struggling to keep up. The brain needs to adapt to the body's longer limbs and different proportions. While the brain adjusts, teens may find that they trip or knock things over more than before.

Self-consciousness

Teens also become more body-aware during puberty. If they feel self-conscious, it can make them even clumsier.

**Risky behavior**

Teens are more likely than adults to seek out thrills and to act on impulse. This is because the teen brain matures from back to front, with the prefrontal cortex—which controls impulses and rational thought—maturing last. As a teen's prefrontal cortex matures last, the amygdala—responsible for instinct and risky behavior—takes control in the meantime and allows teens to become more independent from their parents.

**Testing boundaries**

Some teens make careless decisions because their brains are more focused on the social rewards of an action rather than the risks.

Brain rest

With the brain and body changing so quickly, teens need an average of nine hours of sleep per night. The changes occurring in the brain also affect their sleep patterns. During adolescence, melatonin (the hormone that encourages sleep) isn't released in the brain until late in the evening, and continues being released in the morning, turning teens into night owls who struggle to wake up early.

**Sleep**

Sleep is vital for the healthy development of the brain and body.

Cerebellum

Responsible for coordinating the body's movement and balance, the cerebellum adjusts as the body grows.

Some scientists believe that the human brain today is 10% smaller than it was 20,000 years ago because it has become more efficient.